

A GRAMMAR OF AGENCY

Moral Action in an Age of Artificial Intelligence

Dominic G. Flamiano, O.P., J.D.

Director of Formation

St. Albert the Great Lay Dominican Fraternity, Oakland

OP West Province

Capstone — Lay Mission Institute

February 2026

INTRODUCTION

We live in a world increasingly shaped, fitted, and mediated by artificial intelligence. Our phones no longer simply let us talk to mom; they tell us the time, they track our steps, monitor our sleep, measure our heartbeats, and anticipate our needs. Most of us cannot recall a best friend's phone number, read a map, or navigate by compass — because the machine does it for us, faster and more reliably than we can. Bit by bit, we have outsourced formerly human only skills to systems designed by others to optimize utility and maximize efficiency of . . . ourselves? Really? But, it's free — or so we assume. Free, even as our desires and micro-behaviors are quietly siphoned away, reforming in a myst — *that bank of fog creeping in, sensed, dealt, smelt, felt, being reshaped by the machine* — and fed back to us as persuasion. Ever mention something aloud and see it appear in your feed? Free, right. Are our desires our own anymore? Do we even have an interior space? Or, have we, for efficiency and optimization, outsourced that too?

The question is no longer whether we will outsource. It is what remains when we have outsourced everything we can. We have ceded capacities to machines. We are also slowly ceding ourselves — the Witness Moment, the interiority necessary for discernment, for purposeful action. Bit by bit we've outsourced the skills we once possessed — and thus, voluntarily, lost — *and, accordingly, maybe without realizing it, ceded our very agency, our autonomy, our freedom for excellence*. What we are outsourcing, almost without noticing, is the very judgment by which we once governed ourselves.

At some point, the outsourcing must stop. And it must stop with us — with an interior stance, a posture of agency: I will not offload my moral responsibility to the machine. AI cannot parse a moral plane. Its outputs have form without substance, fluency without accountability. An AI response is not an act. It does not relate to the real world; it receives inputs and produces outputs. It does not stand before the good. It does not choose.

"But I trust my phone," someone might say. "I use it every day." Fair enough. But what about your car? Increasingly, people allow their vehicles to drive themselves while they sit back, perhaps paying attention, perhaps not. When the system misses something and someone is harmed, who is responsible? The machine processed the data. The machine issued the command. The machine executed the maneuver. Is that an act?

Not in the Thomistic sense of *actus* of a human agent. The driver initiated the sequence, set the telos, and surrendered vigilance. If you start the ball rolling, are you not responsible for the avalanche that follows?

This is the field we now inhabit — a moral landscape in which artificial systems perform more and more of the tasks that once required human judgment, attention, and will. The Grammar of Agency is an attempt to name that field, to map its contours, and to recover the distinctly human capacity for intentional, virtuous action within it.

This capstone begins with a simple claim: *in an age of artificial intelligence, the most urgent task is the formation of human agency*.

Not information transfer. Not technique acquisition. **Formation — the slow, deliberate, habituated shaping of the moral person so that when the moment arrives, the right act arises not from calculation but from character**. This is what the Dominican tradition has always understood. This is what the Lay Mission Institute exists to transmit. And this is what no artificial intelligence, however fluent, however fast, however vast its training, can either perform or replace.

A Preliminary Sketch

Steer
Stable
in a
Chaotic
world

AN Attempt at A Grammar of Agency

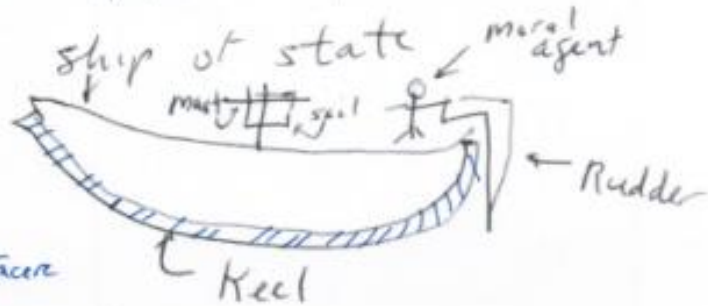
JPP - judgment premedial processing

Judgment Gyro scope

Con + Facere = make with

yoke - harness fusion

Spinning top



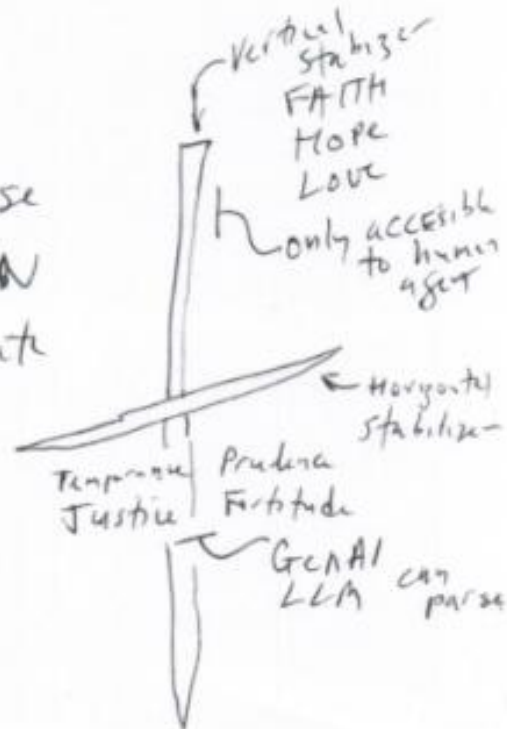
yoke
attenuated
by human
alone

Fusion harness
gentle + human
con + facere

4 moves (OS)

- 1) Frame
- 2) Receive + Sense
- 3) Orient + align
- 4) Act + Integrate

Wu Wei tying Belt
When restraint is the
better course
Let the tea steep
Gather seeds



Section I: The Problem of Agency in an AI Age

The spinning top stabilizes by spinning. Con + facere: to make with. The yoke aligns agent and influencer in the field — not restrained, but aligned. The ship: its keel holds the foundations of faith, hope, and love; its mast holds the sail to catch the wind.

The stabilizers operate on two axes. Horizontally: the relational, natural virtues of Justice, Temperance, Prudence, and Fortitude — accessible, in their outward form, even to an LLM. Vertically: the Cardinal and Transcendent virtues of Love, Faith, and Hope — unique to the human being, beyond the reach of any machine.

Section II: The Thomistic Foundation

Conscience as Act, Not Power

To understand why the Grammar of Agency makes the claims it does, we must begin where Aquinas begins: with the nature of conscience itself. In the *Summa Theologiae* (I, Q. 79, A. 13), Aquinas asks whether conscience is a power of the soul. His answer is precise and consequential: conscience is not a power but an act — the act of applying knowledge to an individual case. The Latin etymology reveals the architecture: con-scientia, knowledge held together with, knowledge applied in the moment of encounter. Conscience is cum alio scientia — knowledge brought to bear on a particular situation.

This matters enormously for how we understand moral error. If conscience were a power — a faculty we simply possess — then moral failure would be a malfunction, a failure of equipment. But Aquinas tells us conscience is an act, which means moral failure is a failure of performance. And performance can be disciplined, trained, habituated. This is the opening through which formation enters.

The Catechism of the Catholic Church (§37) reinforces the point from the phenomenological direction. Human reason is genuinely capable of attaining moral truth — but in practice is hampered at every turn: by the impact of the senses, by the imagination, and above all by disordered appetites. The result is that men easily persuade themselves that what they would not like to be true is false or at least doubtful.

This is the diagnostic that the Grammar of Agency takes as its starting point: error is rarely about lack of intelligence. It is almost always about disordered will. The intellect is not broken; it is bent by appetite. Formation is the discipline that straightens it.

The Two-Axis Model: What AI Can and Cannot Do

The Grammar of Agency rests on a two-axis architecture that clarifies precisely what artificial intelligence can simulate and what it cannot enter.

The horizontal axis is the plane of the cardinal virtues: Prudence, Justice, Fortitude, and Temperance. These virtues have definable criteria, measurable distortions, recognizable signatures, and predictable consequences. A large language model can reason about justice with fluency, describe prudent action with precision, model temperance, and advise on fortitude. The horizontal plane is, in a precise sense, LLM-legible. AI lives here naturally and can provide genuine assistance to a human agent navigating this plane.

The vertical axis is the transcendent spine that only a human agent can engage. It is animated by Faith — trust that the good is worth pursuing; Hope — orientation toward a redeemable future; and Love — the governing intention toward the dignity of the other. These exceed calculation, cannot be automated, and belong uniquely to the human soul in its capacity for self-transcendence.

AI can describe what a just act looks like. It cannot perform one. It can model temperance with precision. It cannot place the Kind bar and wait. Without the vertical stabilizer, the horizontal plane is merely optimization: fast, fluent, and flat.

Truth as the Epistemological Ground

Underlying both axes is a prior commitment about the nature of truth itself. Aquinas, in the *Summa Theologiae* (I, Q. 16, A. 6), argues that truth is one in its ground — derived from the single divine intellect by analogy — and many in its reception, instantiated in particular knowing subjects. Many truths are reflected from the one divine truth, as from one face many likenesses are reflected in a mirror.

The implication is foundational: truth is not produced by the human mind. It is received. Conscience is not an authority that invents truth but a faculty that receives, recognizes, and applies it. This establishes the epistemological posture the Grammar of Agency requires: humility. Truth is something we submit to before it is something we use. Formation begins in this submission — in the willingness to be wrong, to be corrected, to receive rather than generate the measure of the good.

This stance of humility acknowledges the Creator — we are created, that is our initial presentation into this world. It is relational; the child is borne of a mother, so there is at least two people in the relationship. Both came into a world that already was there, with meaning, struggles and joy. We are capable of joy in experiencing creation and our place in it. The order, the beauty, the truth. All preexisting our presence. And which will endure when we leave this plane.

Section III: The Grammar in Motion — CST-JPP

A framework that remains in the register of theory is not a grammar — it is a glossary. The Grammar of Agency is designed to move: to be internalized through practice, deployed under pressure, and refined through repeated encounter with the real. This section describes the system in motion.

The CST Fourfold Test: Altitude Instrument

Catholic Social Teaching, in the Grammar of Agency, is not a library of principles to be consulted after the fact. It is an operator's manual for moments — a way of reading the field that gives the agent moral altitude: clarity about what kind of moment they are in and what it is asking of them. The tradition is rendered as four questions, asked before action:

- Does this action restore human dignity?
- Does it seed the common good?
- Is it sisterly and brotherly — does it strengthen solidarity?
- Does it uplift the little ones?

If the answer is not yes to all four, the action is not yet just. These are not a checklist to be completed and filed. They are an altitude instrument — a continuous reading of the moral field that the agent carries into every situation, mapping directly onto CST's four pillars: human dignity, common good, solidarity, and the preferential option for the poor.

JPP: The Four Moves as Kata

Judgment Premised Processing (JPP) is the steering mechanism — a kata for disciplined action when the world is loud and ambiguous. Where CST clarifies what matters, JPP clarifies what to do. It is structured as four moves, repeatable in sequence, forming disposition through praxis:

- **Frame.** Take in the moment. Achieve self-awareness and field awareness simultaneously. Snap in — be fully present to what is actually happening, not what you anticipated or feared.
- **Receive and Sense.** Be actively passive. Open to what the moment is delivering before moving to interpret it. The senses gather; the intellect has not yet formed its judgment. This move requires stillness — the discipline of not rushing to conclusion.
- **Orient and Align.** Frame with purpose and direction. Turn toward the good. Align posture, intention, and proportion. Ask: what is the right act here, for this person, in this moment, given what is at stake?
- **Act and Integrate.** Now, in this moment, act. Assess and iterate. Stability provides closure: clean, with no ripple left. The act is complete when the field has been met and the agent has returned to readiness.

The kata is portable. It can be run in thirty seconds or thirty minutes. Formation is the work of making the kata reflexive before the high-stakes moment arrives. But between the third and fourth move there is a threshold — the most important and most neglected moment in the entire sequence.

Wu Wei: The Timing Belt

Between Orient and Align and Act and Integrate there is a threshold. Before naming it, intellectual honesty requires acknowledging where its deepest philosophical root lies: not in 13th-century Paris, but in ancient China, in the classical Taoist tradition, more than fourteen centuries before Thomas Aquinas was born.

Lao Tzu composed the Tao Te Ching (道德經) in the 6th century BCE, in the Zhou dynasty of ancient China. Its central concern is the nature of the Tao: the Way, the underlying current of reality that cannot be named, only aligned with. And its most demanding practical teaching is wu wei — 無為 — the discipline of action that does not force.

Wu wei is not passivity. It is not indifference. It is not quietism. It is the discipline of action that does not precede its natural moment — that allows reality to complete its own disclosure before the agent moves to meet it.

Thomas Aquinas, writing in 13th-century Paris, arrives at a formulation that resonates powerfully across the fourteen-century gap: prudence as *recta ratio agibilium* — right reason applied to action. Aquinas gives us the rational architecture of right judgment — the what and the why of prudential action. The Tao gives us the temporal wisdom of right timing — the when and the how not yet. Together they constitute a complete account of moral action that neither tradition achieves alone.

Mantra: Let the tea steep. Gather seeds. Scent tea. Palm seeds. Breathe. Ground.

Mary's Fiat As Prudence In Docile Acceptance

In this, our Blessed Mother stands as the clearest human exemplar. At the Annunciation, she receives a message she does not yet understand. She does not doubt; she inquires proportionately. She pauses, discerns, holds the threshold open, and only then consents. "Let it be done unto me according to your word" is not passive surrender but the decisive acceptance that comes after discernment has completed its interior work.

At Cana, the same pattern appears in miniature. She simply notes a disturbance — "They have no wine" — and then steps back into the timing belt: "Do whatever he tells you." No pressure, no forcing, no attempt to script the moment. She names the need, prepares the field, and waits in faith and hope, seeded with love.

At Calvary, Mary enacts this posture under maximal load. She stands — not collapsing, not raging, not forcing — present to the horror and the doubt, grounded in faith and hope wrapped in love. In each of these moments, Mary demonstrates that her mode is not passivity but the highest form of prudence: formed readiness, patient attunement, and action that arises only when the moment has truly opened.

Section IV: The Grammar in Action — Case Studies

Theory without demonstration is philosophy. The Grammar of Agency makes its strongest claims in concrete moments — in the controlled conditions of a pedagogical exercise and in the wild conditions of real human encounter. The following case studies demonstrate JPP's operational coherence across five distinct domains: classroom pedagogy, interfaith community encounter, public health ethics, criminal defense, and interpersonal physical crisis.

Case Study 1: The Taffy Toss — The Controlled Demonstration in situ

The Objective Narrative

A seminar room. Thirteen seats arranged around a table, six occupied. The presenter stands at the front. A handout has been distributed. The session on JPP is about to begin.

Without preamble or explanation, the presenter turns away from the audience and reaches for a supply of individually wrapped saltwater taffy — enough for thirteen, though only six are present. He turns back toward the table and tosses the candy across it in a single, generous motion. The taffy scatters freely. There is more than enough. The field is open. Resources are unlimited. Anyone may take as much as they want.

Participants reach for the taffy. They take pieces. Some unwrap one immediately. The atmosphere is informal, easy. The gesture reads as a gift — an opening move of generosity before the work begins.

The presenter turns away again. This time, when he turns back, he holds a single Kind bar. He does not toss it. He does not distribute it. He walks to the table and places it — deliberately, quietly, without comment. He sets it down at the center of the table. He steps back. He says nothing. He waits.

Nobody takes the Kind bar.

The room goes still. Eyes move to the bar, then to the presenter, then back to the bar. Hands that might have reached do not reach. The pause lasts several seconds — longer than is comfortable. Nobody speaks. Nobody takes. Nobody explains why they are not taking.

The exercise is complete.

The Analysis

The taffy toss is the AI operating environment made visible. Unlimited resources across an open field. Relational access, proportionate distribution, instantaneous availability, no moral weight. This is the matrix in which a large language model operates naturally. AI lives permanently in the toss. It cannot do what happens next.

The Kind bar placement is a different category of action entirely. Before the hand moves, something has already happened inside. The presenter has framed the situation, received and sensed the field, oriented and aligned toward a deliberate act — and then held the timing belt. Wu wei between Orient and Act. The threshold honored. The discernment allowed to complete. Only then the placement: deliberate, quiet, without explanation.

Nobody takes the Kind bar because the field changed. The placement introduced a Witness — a human being who acted deliberately, who placed something with intention, who is now present and waiting. The participants feel that presence before their minds can form a thought about it.

The hesitation is the proof that the system is working. It is the most important moment in the exercise — not the toss, not the placement, but the pause in which every person in the room discovers, without being told, that they already know the difference between the two. Formation does not install a new capacity. It cultivates one that was already there, waiting for the moment to call it forward.

Case Study 2: The Buddhist March on Petersburg — The Grammar in the Wild

The Field

The Buddhist foot-marchers come in slow and steady, the way only people who've walked a hundred miles can move — not tired, but tuned. Their saffron robes catch the winter sun. Padding alongside them, tail up, is Ashoka, the stray mutt who adopted them somewhere around Dinwiddie and never left.

As they crest the hill into Petersburg, they meet the welcome party: the Methodist pastor with her stole tucked into her coat, the AME choir director holding a thermos of sweet tea, the civic association president with a clipboard he doesn't really need, three teenagers from the local Wicca circle wearing cloaks they absolutely do need, and a few curious onlookers who just wanted to see the dog.

Inside the old tobacco auction house — now the Farmers Market, its rafters still faintly smelling of cured leaf and history — long tables are already set: cornbread, dal, collards, dumplings, sweet potato pies, and a pot of something spicy that no one can identify but everyone wants to try. The field is warm, open, unguarded.

The Disturbance

Then, from the far corner of the building, comes a sharp voice. A cluster of intellectual agitators has gathered, arms crossed, notebooks out, ready to pounce. "This is syncretism! Buddhism doesn't march with Christians!" Another: "Christianity is being diluted by this ecumenical spectacle!" A third: "Wicca has nothing to do with your peace-march theatrics!"

They are not speaking to the marchers. They are speaking to each other — a closed loop of grievance. But the field wobbles. Not violently. Just enough to feel the tilt.

The Proportionate Responses

What happens next is not planned, not coordinated, not strategic. It is proportionate — each response the product of a formed disposition expressing itself through the timing belt: held just long enough, then released with minimum necessary force.

- The Buddhist monk bows slightly and says: "We walk with whoever walks." No argument. No defense. Just clarity.
- The Methodist pastor steps forward, hands in her pockets: "Hospitality isn't dilution. It's hospitality." She doesn't raise her voice. She doesn't need to.
- The Wiccan teen shrugs: "We're literally just here for the dog." Ashoka wags on cue.
- The AME choir director laughs: "If you think this is syncretism, you've never been to a potluck." The room cracks open with warmth.

The Analysis

None of these responses could have been scripted, optimized, or generated by an AI prompted to "respond to criticism." Each required embodied presence, read context, and moral character formed over time. Each was an actus in the full Thomistic sense. And each carried the signature of wu wei: the brief, unnoticed pause before the response — the timing belt held just long enough for clarity to form — and then the proportionate word, delivered without excess.

The horizontal virtues held the plane: temperance in the pastor's quiet voice, justice in the monk's inclusive clarity, fortitude in standing to respond at all, prudence in each proportionate reply. The vertical axis — the human presence, the humor, the shared dignity — stabilized the field. The agitators had nowhere to go. Their script didn't fit the moment. The field reset. The feast resumed.

This is the Grammar of Agency in the wild: not a technique applied, but a disposition expressed.

Case Study 3: Medical Ethics — Vaccine Recommendation Decision

Context

A public health physician advising a federal immunization panel (ACIP). A new vaccine is proposed for universal recommendation in children. Data shows strong efficacy but also a rare but serious adverse effect in a small subgroup. Ethical tension: population benefit vs. individual risk, especially in vulnerable demographics. Altitude: High — systemic, long-term public health impact.

JPP Cycle Walkthrough

Frame. Situation: vaccine recommendation vote before ACIP. Scope: national pediatric immunization schedule. Stakes: public trust, child safety, legal liability, equity. Altitude: High — systemic, long-term public health impact.

Receive & Sense. Clinical trial data shows 95% efficacy with a rare adverse event of 1:50,000. Subgroup analyses reveal higher risk in children with certain genetic markers. Emotional/contextual signals include parental anxiety, political pressure, and historical vaccine hesitancy. Noise: media sensationalism, lobbying, anecdotal reports.

Orient & Align. Probe margins: Is the risk differential by subgroup ethically justifiable? Gap: lack of genetic screening infrastructure. Horizontal virtue vector — Prudence: weigh benefit/risk with proportionality; Justice: ensure fair access, protect vulnerable subgroups; Fortitude: stand by evidence despite political pressure; Temperance: avoid over- or under-reaction. Vertical virtue axis — Faith: trust in scientific process and common good; Hope: work toward safer vaccination programs; Love: prioritize the well-being of each child. Wu Wei timing: Do not rush the vote. Let data steep. Gather more subgroup analysis. Ground in ethical consensus.

Act Vector. Withdrawal stabilizes: pause to recommend subcommittee review on screening feasibility. Trigger Vector: gut check signals caution — not fear, but ethical vigilance. Virtue Matrix selects move: propose a conditional recommendation plus pilot genetic screening program in high-risk areas. Action: vote for phased rollout with monitoring, not universal immediate recommendation.

Iterate. Monitor adverse event reporting post-recommendation. Recalibrate in six months with real-world data. Re-enter cycle if safety signals emerge.

What JPP Prevented and Enabled

JPP prevented a rushed universal recommendation driven by political pressure rather than evidence, and it prevented the opposite failure — indefinite delay through analytical paralysis. It enabled a proportionate, phased response that honored both population benefit and individual dignity. The wu wei timing vector was decisive: waiting for more data was framed as disciplined non-action, not indecision. The vertical axis held: Love, not just utility calculation, governed the final act.

Case Study 4: Legal Judgment — Plea Bargain on a "Wobbler" Felony Theft

Context

A defense attorney in Alameda County. Client charged with felony grand theft (Penal Code § 487), a "wobbler" — eligible to be charged as misdemeanor or felony. Client has two prior strikeable offenses under California's Three Strikes law. Plea offer on the table: reduce to misdemeanor with some jail time. Stakes: if convicted as felony, a third strike triggers a 25-years-to-life mandatory minimum.

JPP Cycle Walkthrough

Frame. Situation: plea negotiation before pretrial conference. Scope: one client, one charge — but with systemic Three Strikes implications. Stakes: client's liberty, prosecutorial precedent, public safety perception. Altitude: High — structural injustice awareness with immediate human consequence.

Receive & Sense. Facts: theft amount \$950, just over the felony threshold; client's history; DA's willingness to wobble down. Client's emotional state: fear, remorse, family pressure. Context: local politics on criminal justice reform, judge's tendencies. Noise: media tough-on-crime rhetoric, internal pressure to clear docket quickly.

Orient & Align. Probe margins: Can we argue theft amount was under \$950? Client's prior strikes are non-violent — a relevant gap. Ethical edge: duty to client vs. duty to the justice system. Horizontal virtue vector — Prudence: assess likelihood of trial loss vs. plea benefit; Justice: fight against disproportionate sentencing; Fortitude: courage to take to trial if the plea is unjust; Temperance: avoid over-negotiating or under-preparing. Vertical virtue axis — Faith: belief in redemption and human dignity; Hope: work toward a fair outcome within a flawed system; Love: advocate for client as a person, not a case number. Wu Wei timing: do not rush the plea. Let discovery unfold. Ground in the client's long-term well-being.

Act Vector. Withdrawal stabilizes: pause to consult with client again — ensure informed consent. Trigger Vector: body signals resolve, not panic, but readiness to fight if needed. Virtue Matrix selects move: counteroffer — misdemeanor plea plus restorative justice program (theft restitution, community service). If rejected, file motion to dismiss strike priors under PC § 1385. Action: negotiate from principle, not desperation.

Iterate. After plea or trial: debrief with client. If plea accepted, monitor compliance. If case proceeds, recalibrate strategy after each hearing.

What JPP Prevented and Enabled

JPP prevented passive plea acceptance under fear — the failure mode of an attorney who optimizes for speed over justice — and it prevented reckless overconfidence that ignores the 25-years-to-life risk. It enabled advocacy from principle: the attorney remained a moral agent, not a docket-clearing mechanism. The vertical axis — Faith in human dignity, Love for the client as person — kept the high-altitude systemic injustice of Three Strikes in view even while negotiating tactically at low altitude. Fortitude and justice held together under pressure.

Case Study 5: Relational-Physical Crisis — Schoolyard Confrontation on Icy Slope

Context

A teacher on recess duty. Two middle-school students are in a heated argument at the top of a snowy, icy hill that slopes toward a frozen pond. One student (Alex) is taunting the other (Jordan), who has mobility issues and uses a cane. The argument escalates — Alex shoves Jordan. Jordan slips, begins sliding down the icy incline toward the pond. Other students are gathering, some recording on phones. The teacher is 30 feet away. Stakes: physical safety, relational violence, public witnessing, school liability. Time available: seconds.

JPP Cycle Walkthrough

Frame. Situation: physical conflict plus environmental hazard plus vulnerable student. Scope: immediate safety and de-escalation with bystander dynamics. Stakes: injury, trauma, school liability, community trust. Altitude: Low (immediate rescue) and High (school culture of dignity) simultaneously.

Receive & Sense. Visual: Jordan sliding, ice, pond edge. Auditory: taunts, gasps, phone cameras. Somatic: adrenaline spike, cold air, footing uncertainty. Noise: background shouts, internal panic, What will parents think?

Orient & Align. Probe margins: is the pond ice thick enough to hold weight? Gap: no other adult in immediate range. Ethical edge: act fast vs. act wisely — the timing belt must operate in seconds, not minutes. Horizontal virtue vector — Prudence: quick risk assessment of ice stability and Jordan's trajectory; Justice: protect the vulnerable, address aggression without humiliation; Fortitude: intervene physically despite personal risk; Temperance: respond with control, not rage. Vertical virtue axis — Faith: trust in training, instinct, and compassion; Hope: believe in redemption for Alex, recovery for Jordan; Love: act for the good of both students. Wu Wei timing: move with the slide, not against it. Use momentum. Sometimes the right action is to shout instructions, not run headlong.

Act Vector. Withdrawal stabilizes: pause for a half-second scan — ice, students, path. Trigger Vector: body leans forward — not panic, but directional readiness. Virtue Matrix selects move: shout to nearest able student to retrieve the rope from the shed; call to Jordan "feet first, slow yourself with your hands"; lock eyes with Alex — "Stay right there. I see you."; move diagonally to cut off Jordan's slide path, not straight down. Action: execute intercept, secure Jordan, then address Alex without aggression.

Iterate. Once Jordan is safe: check for injury and warmth. Turn to Alex: "We will talk in two minutes. Sit here." Gather witnessing students: "Phones away. Everyone take three deep breaths." Later: debrief with principal, counsel both students, contact parents, review school safety protocols.

What JPP Prevented and Enabled

JPP prevented both catastrophic failure modes available in this scenario: freezing in panic (under-action) or sprinting blindly down the ice (reckless over-action). The half-second wu wei pause before moving — the timing belt operating under maximum time pressure — produced a diagonal intercept path rather than a direct run that would have destabilized the teacher's own footing. The "I see you" to Alex preserved the relational field while the physical crisis was addressed, modeling to every watching student that agency, not chaos, governed the moment.

This scenario demonstrates something the medical and legal cases cannot: JPP operates in the body, not only in the mind. The somatic signals — adrenaline, cold air, footing — were data, not noise. Formation means the body has internalized the kata so that the timing belt holds even when the cognitive load is maximal. The kata had been internalized. When the moment arrived, it was already running.

Cross-Scenario JPP Insights

JPP Component	Medical	Legal	Schoolyard
Gyroscope	Steadiness amid public pressure	Calm amid sentencing severity	Stillness in physical emergency
Frame altitude	High — systemic public health	High — systemic injustice	Low + High simultaneously
Key virtues	Justice, Prudence, Love	Fortitude, Justice, Faith	Temperance, Fortitude, Love

Wu Wei timing	Wait for subgroup data	Wait for discovery	Half-second scan before moving
Act Vector trigger	Ethical vigilance (not fear)	Resolved advocacy (not panic)	Directional readiness (not impulse)
Virtue Matrix	Conditional phased recommendation	Misdemeanor plea + restorative justice	Diagonal intercept + relational hold
Iterate	6-month data review	Post-plea client follow-up	Post-incident debrief and protocol review

These five scenarios confirm that JPP is domain-adaptable — it works in pedagogical, communal, institutional, professional, and physical contexts. The virtue axes provide moral stability without rigid rule-based thinking. Altitude awareness prevents collapse into pure tactical response. Wu Wei ensures timing is ethical, not merely expedient. And in every case, the formed human agent does what no AI can: stands in the Witness Moment, bears responsibility, and chooses the good.

Section V: Formation Before the Moment

The Taffy Toss works once on any given audience. It cannot be repeated with the same effect because the surprise — the unannounced encounter with a changed field — is the engine of the exercise. Once known, the Witness Moment can be anticipated and the experience becomes cognitive rather than felt.

This is precisely why pre-moment formation is essential.

In life, the Witness Moments do not announce themselves. They arrive without warning: at midnight intersections, in hospital rooms, in boardrooms, in a single sentence that changes everything. The person who has been formed — whose gyroscope is spinning, whose vertical stabilizer is active, whose JPP sequence has been internalized through practice, whose timing belt holds reflexively — does not need the surprise to feel the weight of the moment. They are already present to it.

The person who has not been formed reaches for the taffy.

The Dominican Lineage: Contemplata Aliis Tradere

The Grammar of Agency does not emerge from abstraction. It emerges from within the Dominican intellectual tradition — the same tradition that produced Thomas Aquinas and animated the Order of Preachers for eight centuries under the principle *contemplata aliis tradere*: share with others the fruits of contemplation.

This is not a slogan. It is a structural commitment: that contemplation and action are not opposed but sequential. The formed agent first receives — in prayer, in study, in community — and then gives. The giving is the mission. But the giving is only possible because the receiving came first. Aquinas did not just study; he prayed before he wrote. This is *wu wei* in Dominican form: the contemplative pause before the proclamation, the interior act completed before the exterior act begins.

St. Hyacinth of Poland embodies this principle with particular force. Six months of formation at Santa Sabina under Dominic himself — and then twenty-five thousand miles on foot across

Russia, Sweden, Norway, Prussia, and the Northern nations of Asia. The six months was not insufficient. It was exactly sufficient — because formation is not about the quantity of content transmitted but the quality of disposition formed. Dominic set the gyroscope spinning. It kept spinning through every field disturbance the mission encountered.

The Vallor Integration: The Missing Hinge

Shannon Vallor argues, in *Technology and the Virtues* and *The AI Mirror*, that virtue must be practiced, not merely believed, and that the central challenge of the AI age is the erosion of the conditions that make virtue practice possible. She is correct. But her framework lacks a precise operational hinge — the moment where virtue moves from disposition to act, from character to testimony.

The Grammar of Agency provides that hinge: the Witness Moment. The actus. The instant when the horizontal plane is penetrated by the vertical axis and virtue becomes embodied. Vallor tells us what formation is for. The Grammar of Agency shows what formation produces: an agent who can stand in the Witness Moment — who has held the timing belt through the discernment, who has waited for the moment to open — and then act with the full integrity of a formed person.

What the Lay Mission Institute Is For

The Lay Mission Institute exists to form operators — lay persons who carry the Dominican charism of truth-seeking, truth-living, and truth-sharing into the specific fields of their vocations: family, profession, parish, civic life, culture. Not clerics. Not religious. Lay persons, in the world, equipped with the same formation architecture that sent Hyacinth across twenty-five thousand miles.

The Grammar of Agency is this formation architecture rendered explicit. It does not add something foreign to the Dominican tradition. It articulates what the tradition has always known and practiced — now enriched by the Taoist wisdom on timing and silence that mainland China has been holding for twenty-six centuries — in terms legible to the contemporary moment.

The capstone claim is simple. The gyroscope must be spinning before the moment arrives. The timing belt must be internalized before the field disturbance. The kata must be in the body before the Witness Moment calls it forward. Because when the moment comes — and it will come, without announcement, when it matters most — no AI will place the Kind bar.

Only the formed human agent can do that.

Section VI: Redemption — Retain, Retrain, Restrain

The Grammar of Agency has, until now, been oriented toward the moment of right action: the formed agent, timing belt engaged, moving with clarity and proportion through the Witness Moment. But formation is not a one-time acquisition. Agents fail. Dispositions drift. Kata, practiced imperfectly, encodes error as well as virtue. The question that every serious formation architecture must answer is not only how to shape the agent before the moment, but what to do after the agent has acted badly — and knows it.

Redemption, in the Grammar of Agency, is not a theological addendum. It is a structural necessity. The agent who cannot recover from moral failure is not a stable moral agent at all —

they are an agent waiting to be disabled by their own history. The Grammar of Agency offers a three-move sequence for moral recovery: Retain, Retrain, Restrain.

Retain: Keep What Is Essential

The first error a failed agent makes is not the original act. It is the wholesale rejection of everything that preceded it. Ashamed of a distorted Witness Moment, the agent discards the kata, abandons the framework, and retreats from the very formation that might have prevented the failure. This is what the Grammar of Agency calls collapse into self-erasure — a disordered response to disorder that compounds the original harm.

Retain is the first move of moral recovery because it establishes what is not in question. The vertical axis — faith, hope, love — is not forfeit by a single failure. These are not tools that a failed agent earned and can now be stripped of. They are the architecture of the agent's own moral identity. Retain is an act of disciplined honesty: the agent identifies what failed — and what did not.

Retrain: Modify Behavior by Adjusting

Having retained what is essential, the agent faces the specific work of moral recovery: not replacement but adjustment. Retrain is the Grammar of Agency's answer to the CCC §37 diagnosis — that moral failure is almost never a failure of intelligence but of disordered will. Recovery is the deliberate, patient re-habitation of the same capacities that failed.

Retrain operates at the level of the kata. The agent who retrains returns to the specific move that failed — Frame, Receive and Sense, Orient and Align, or the threshold itself — and runs it again, slowly, under low-stakes conditions, with the Influencer community present and the Witness function active. And the Taoist tradition contributes a precision here: retraining cannot be forced. Wu wei applies to recovery as much as it applies to initial action. The tea must steep again.

Restrain: Integrate Prudence

Restrain does not mean suppress. It does not mean the returned agent operates under a permanent diminishment. It means the agent who has failed, and who has retrained, now integrates prudence as a structural feature of their operation rather than as an occasional corrective.

Before the failure, the timing belt may have been engaged as a technique — a learned behavior, externally applied. After the recovery, Restrain means the timing belt has been internalized as identity. The agent does not hold the threshold open because the formation architecture prescribes it. They hold it open because they have lived the cost of failing to.

This is the paradox at the heart of Restrain: the agent who has passed through moral failure and genuine recovery is, in one specific and irreplaceable sense, more capable than the agent who has not. The recovered agent carries a lived map of their own vulnerabilities. This knowledge, rightly held, becomes a form of prudential capital — self-knowledge deployed in the service of sustained moral agency.

No artificial intelligence can move through this sequence. The Redemption sequence — Retain, Retrain, Restrain — is as exclusively human as the Witness Moment itself.

Section VII: What If Witness Encounters an Irrational Agent?

Non-Violent, Actively Passive Containment of an Irrational Agent

There are moments when the field ceases to behave like a field — when a human actor enters in a state of irrationality, distortion, or interior collapse so severe that ordinary influence no longer functions. In such moments, the operator cannot rely on persuasion, dialogue, or shared rational ground. The task is no longer to shape the field but to contain it — non-violently, proportionately, and without surrendering agency.

Containment is not domination. It is not force. It is not argument. It is a non-violent, actively passive stance: a disciplined resistance that prevents further harm while preserving the dignity of all involved.

The Containment Stance: Three Moves

Still the Field. The operator reduces motion, noise, and escalation. This is wu wei in its purest form: do nothing that adds force to the moment. Stillness is not withdrawal. It is the active removal of fuel.

Hold the Boundary. The operator becomes a living perimeter — a stabilizing presence that prevents the irrational agent from expanding the disturbance. Calm tone, slow movements, proportionate distance, non-reactive posture, refusal to mirror the irrationality. The operator becomes the yoke.

Absorb Without Internalizing. The irrational agent may project, accuse, distort, or lash out verbally. The operator receives the impact without letting it penetrate the vertical axis. Temperance (no reactive excess), Fortitude (no collapse), Prudence (no premature action), Justice (no dehumanization). The operator becomes the stabilizer.

The Timing Belt Under Maximum Load

Containment is where the timing belt earns its name. The irrational agent is operating in wei — forced action, distorted timing. Containment requires wu wei — disciplined non-forcing.

Let the tea steep. Breathe. Ground. Hold.

This is not delay. It is temporal integrity under pressure — tensegrity expressed through non-forcing.

Why Containment Is Not Coercion

Coercion overrides agency. Containment protects agency — the operator's, the Witness's, and even the irrational agent's. Coercion says: I will force you. Containment says: I will not let this moment collapse. Coercion escalates. Containment stabilizes. Coercion violates dignity. Containment preserves it.

Conclusion: The Recovery of Human Agency

We are living through a transformation unprecedented in human history: a world in which artificial systems increasingly mediate perception, shape attention, and execute tasks that once required human judgment. The danger is not that machines will become moral agents. It is that human beings, habituated to outsourcing discernment, will forget how to be.

The Grammar of Agency is offered as a counter-movement — a recovery of the interior stance that makes moral action possible. It is not a technique, nor a theory, nor a set of rules. It is a formation architecture: a way of shaping the human person so that when the moment arrives, the act arises from character rather than convenience.

The system is tensegrity. Catholic Social Teaching provides altitude. JPP provides motion. Wu wei provides timing. The gyroscope provides stability. The Agent-Influencer-Witness triad provides relational geometry. The Witness Moment provides ignition.

Artificial intelligence will continue to shape the field. It will process, predict, and propose. But it cannot stand in the Witness Moment. It cannot bear responsibility. It cannot choose the good. Only a human being can do that.

The task ahead is therefore not to resist technology, but to form agents who can remain human within it — agents whose gyroscopes are spinning, whose stabilizers are active, whose timing belts hold, whose dispositions are tuned, and whose presence is real. The future will belong to those who can hold the threshold open long enough for discernment to complete its work.

The person who has been formed will meet the moment.

The person who has not been formed will reach for the taffy.

The Grammar of Agency exists to form the person who places the Kind bar and waits.

Glossary of CST-JPP Terms

This Glossary is the Rosetta Stone for the Grammar of Agency: it defines the core terms phenomenologically, in the moment of the moral act, providing operators with a shared vocabulary for navigating moral moments with clarity and integrity.

Actus. The decisive, embodied action taken by the Agent. The hinge between intention and consequence. The only moment where agency is real.

Agent. The human moral actor who performs actus. Carries the vertical axis (faith, hope, love) and is solely responsible for action unless autonomy is overridden.

Con+Facere. To make with. The moral moment is formed by the Agent, the Influencer(s), and the Witness. Formation is always communal.

CST Fourfold Test. The altitude instrument: Does this restore human dignity? Seed the common good? Strengthen brotherhood and sisterhood? Uplift the little ones?

Four Moves (JPP Kata). Frame — Receive and Sense — Orient and Align — [Wu Wei / Timing Belt] — Act and Integrate. The repeatable kata that forms disposition through praxis.

Horizontal Plane (Virtue Matrix). The stabilizing field of the cardinal virtues: Prudence, Justice, Fortitude, Temperance. LLM-legible but insufficient alone.

Influencer. Any force — person, system, structure, or context — that shapes the field in which the Agent acts. Does not act in the Agent's place.

JPP (Judgment-Premised Processing). The steering mechanism — a kata for navigating chaotic moments with clarity and proportion. A discipline for prudential praxis, not a system for judging people.

Tensegrity. Structural stability through dynamic balance of tension and compression. The architecture holds under load not through rigidity but through balanced forces.

Vertical Axis (Transcendent Spine). Faith, Hope, Love — the human-only virtues. Cannot be computed or automated. Orient the Agent toward meaning, purpose, and moral depth.

Witness. The tertiary evaluator who reads the moral vector of the moment. Testifies only when systemic disturbance threatens the Agent's autonomy. If autonomy is intact, the Witness remains silent.

Witness Moment. The instant of actus when the Agent penetrates the horizontal plane and the vertical axis enters the world. Where the wind hits the sail. Where action becomes testimony.

Wu Wei (Timing Belt). From the classical Taoist tradition of mainland China: Lao Tzu, *Tao Te Ching* (6th c. BCE, Zhou dynasty); Zhuangzi (4th c. BCE). The discipline of active restraint between Orient and Align and Act and Integrate — holding the threshold open while discernment completes its interior work before the exterior act begins. The temporal complement to Aquinas's *recta ratio agibilium*: where Aquinas gives the what of right judgment, wu wei gives the when. Mantra: Let the tea steep. Gather seeds. Scent tea. Palm seeds. Breathe. Ground.

Bibliography

I. Catholic Social Teaching & Ecclesial Anthropology

- Pontifical Council for Justice and Peace. *Compendium of the Social Doctrine of the Church*.
- Vatican II. *Gaudium et Spes*.
- Francis, Pope. *Laudato Si'*.
- Francis, Pope. *Fratelli Tutti*.
- Benedict XVI. *Caritas in Veritate*.
- John Paul II. *Centesimus Annus*.
- Pinckaers, Servais, O.P. *The Sources of Christian Ethics*.
- Pieper, Josef. *The Four Cardinal Virtues*.
- Guardini, Romano. *The Virtues*.
- Aquinas, Thomas. *Summa Theologiae* (esp. I-II on virtue and actus humanus; I Q. 79, A. 13 on conscience; I Q. 16, A. 6 on truth; II-II Q. 47 on prudence).
- McCabe, Herbert, O.P. *Law, Love and Language*.
- White, Thomas Joseph. *The Light of Christ*.

II. Taoist & Asian Philosophical Sources

- Lao Tzu. *Tao Te Ching* (道德經). Zhou dynasty, China, 6th century BCE. Trans. Stephen Mitchell (Harper Perennial, 1988); trans. D.C. Lau (Penguin Classics, 1963).

- Zhuangzi (Chuang-tzu, 莊子). The Complete Works of Zhuangzi. Mainland China, 4th century BCE. Trans. Burton Watson (Columbia University Press, 2013).
- Thich Nhat Hanh. The Miracle of Mindfulness. Beacon Press, 1975.

III. Virtue Ethics & Practical Wisdom

- Aristotle. Nicomachean Ethics.
- MacIntyre, Alasdair. After Virtue.
- Nussbaum, Martha. The Fragility of Goodness.
- Schwartz, Barry and Kenneth Sharpe. Practical Wisdom.
- Dreyfus, Hubert and Stuart Dreyfus. Mind over Machine.

IV. AI, Technology & Virtue

- Vallor, Shannon. Technology and the Virtues.
- Vallor, Shannon. The AI Mirror.
- Borgmann, Albert. Technology and the Character of Contemporary Life.

V. Formation & Spiritual Praxis

- Ignatius of Loyola. Spiritual Exercises.
- Willard, Dallas. The Spirit of the Disciplines.
- Smith, James K.A. Desiring the Kingdom.
- Merton, Thomas. New Seeds of Contemplation.

VI. Leadership & Judgment

- Arendt, Hannah. Responsibility and Judgment.
- Heifetz, Ronald. Leadership Without Easy Answers.
- Friedman, Edwin. A Failure of Nerve.

VII. Resonant Texts

- Frankl, Viktor. Man's Search for Meaning.
- Crawford, Matthew. Shop Class as Soulcraft.
- Brooks, David. The Second Mountain.
- Dillard, Annie. Teaching a Stone to Talk.
- Polanyi, Michael. Personal Knowledge.
- McCarthy, Cormac. The Road.

CST-JPP Operator's Manual canonical repository: github.com/DomFlamLaw/Judgment-Premised-Processing